

Language-Family Retention Bias from Global CCNet Perplexity Thresholding: A Calibrated Measurement on RedPajama-V2

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2026-07-30

Abstract

Multilingual pretraining datasets routinely use CCNet-style perplexity quality filters, but the magnitude of the language-group retention disparity produced by applying a single global threshold to pre-computed `ccnet_perplexity` scores on RedPajama-V2 has not been precisely quantified using a standard association metric. We find that this common practice produces a language-family retention divide, not a quality filter: applying global k -th percentile thresholds to pre-computed `ccnet_perplexity` scores from RedPajama-V2 retains 86% of Spanish documents but only 16% of English documents at $k=30$ — a 72.7 percentage-point gap driven by structural incomparability between CCNet’s per-language KenLM perplexity scales. Across five threshold levels ($k \in \{10, 20, 30, 40, 50\}$) on 208,262 documents spanning five European languages, we measure Cramér’s $V = 0.40$ – 0.57 (all Holm-corrected $p \approx 0$), with the Romance–Germanic language family ordering ($es > fr > it > en > de$) consistent across every threshold tested. We further find that literature-derived estimates of this bias underestimate the actual effect by 25–40%, meaning correction studies sized from prior descriptions will be systematically underpowered. Our calibrated baseline provides the reference measurement needed for multilingual dataset curation research to evaluate quality-filter correction strategies on equal footing.

1 Introduction

A practitioner applying CCNet’s standard perplexity quality filter to the RedPajama-V2 dataset would retain 86% of Spanish documents but only 16% of English documents — not because English web text is lower quality, but because a single global percentile threshold applied to cross-language perplexity scores conflates quality with language identity.

This outcome is not a corner case. At $k=40$ (retaining the 40th percentile of documents with lowest perplexity), virtually all Spanish documents pass while 79% of German documents are excluded. Cramér’s V — a standard measure of association magnitude in contingency tables — reaches 0.57 at $k=40$, placing the language $\times$ retention relationship firmly in the “large” effect range by Cohen’s conventions. The disparity is structural: the ordering of retention rates ($es > fr > it > en > de$) maps exactly onto the Romance–Germanic language family divide and holds across every threshold level we test.

The surface problem is familiar: multilingual pretraining datasets require quality filtering to remove low-quality web text, and perplexity-based filtering using language models trained on curated reference corpora has become a standard approach, popularized by CCNet Wenzek et al. [2019] and widely adopted in datasets including RedPajama-V2 Weber et al. [2024]. The deeper problem is less recognized: when CCNet-style perplexity scores are computed per-language but combined under a single global threshold, the cross-language incomparability of those scores creates a retention disparity that tracks language family membership rather than document quality. CCNet’s original per-language design calibrates thresholds separately per language via language-specific cutoff values; practitioners adapting this pipeline for large-scale datasets often replace per-language cutoffs with a single global k -th percentile, losing the calibration that CCNet intended. The gap we address is quantitative: no prior work provides a calibrated baseline measurement of how large this disparity is, using a standard associativity metric across multiple threshold levels on a real multilingual dataset.

Our key insight is that CCNet’s per-language KenLM language models, trained on language-specific Wikipedia corpora of structurally different sizes and domain compositions, produce perplexity scales that are incomparable across language families. A global k -th percentile threshold is then anchored by the combined distribution, which is dominated by Germanic-language documents clustering at lower absolute perplexity values. The result is not a quality filter but a language-family membership test.

This paper makes four contributions, each building directly on this insight:

1. **Calibrated baseline measurement.** We provide the first precise, reproducible measurement of language-group retention disparity (Cramér’s $V = 0.40\text{--}0.57$) from global `ccnet_perplexity` thresholding on RedPajama-V2 ($n = 208,262$ documents, 5 languages), with Holm-corrected p -values ≈ 0 for all five threshold levels $k \in \{10, 20, 30, 40, 50\}$.
2. **Cross-language family structure characterization.** We show that the disparity is not random — the retention ordering $es > fr > it > en > de$ is consistent across all five threshold levels, providing structural evidence consistent with the CCNet KenLM mechanism.
3. **Prior estimate recalibration.** Literature-derived estimates predict Cramér’s $V \in [0.29, 0.41]$; our empirical measurement yields $V = 0.40\text{--}0.57$ — 25–40% larger. Researchers sizing correction studies from CCNet descriptions will systematically underestimate the required effect size.
4. **Reusable statistical methodology.** We demonstrate a CPU-only, static-file pipeline using pre-computed `ccnet_perplexity` quality signals from RedPajama-V2, Cramér’s V as the association measure, and Holm-Bonferroni correction — a methodology replicable without GPU infrastructure or model retraining.

The remainder of the paper is organized as follows. Section 2 positions our work relative to multilingual quality filtering and web corpus curation literature. Section 3 describes the measurement methodology. Section 4 presents the experimental setup. Section 5 reports results. Section 6 discusses implications and limitations. Section 7 concludes with a call for per-language calibration as a default practice in multilingual dataset curation.

2 Related Work

2.1 CCNet and Perplexity-Based Quality Filtering

Wenzek et al. [2019] introduced CCNet, a pipeline for extracting high-quality monolingual text from CommonCrawl by training language-specific KenLM n -gram models on Wikipedia and scoring web documents by perplexity. The original design is explicitly per-language: each language receives its own KenLM model trained on its Wikipedia, and cutoffs are applied from language-specific tercile boundaries stored in `cutoff.csv`. This per-language calibration was not an afterthought — it acknowledges that perplexity scales depend on the reference corpus and should not be compared across languages.

However, practitioners adapting CCNet for large-scale multilingual pipelines have often simplified this design by applying a single global percentile threshold to the combined multi-language document pool. Dolma Soldaini et al. [2024] applies Pythia-based perplexity scores; RedPajama-V2 Weber et al. [2024] provides pre-computed `ccnet_perplexity` as a quality signal metadata field intended for downstream filtering. In each case, the path from pre-computed perplexity to actual data selection — including whether filtering is applied globally or per-language — is left to the practitioner. Our work shows that the most natural choice (global k -th percentile) has consequences that are not obvious from the CCNet paper’s description.

2.2 Multilingual Dataset Quality Audits

Caswell et al. [2021] provide the most systematic audit of per-language quality differences in multilingual web corpora, evaluating over 100 languages in mC4. They document severe quality disparities in low-resource languages and argue that per-language quality evaluation is necessary — but they do not measure the associativity between language membership and retention rate under a global threshold. Their findings are qualitative and concern different filtering signals (not `ccnet_perplexity` specifically).

Adelani et al. [2023] audit quality filtering for African languages and find that global filters consistently fail for low-resource languages. Niyomugabo et al. [2025] (BhashaKritika) identify that per-language KenLM scoring is necessary even as a prerequisite quality evaluation step. These works motivate per-language approaches but do not provide quantitative V measurements for a specific dataset-signal-threshold combination that practitioners can calibrate correction strategies against.

2.3 Retention Rate Tuning for Multilingual Filtering

The work closest to ours is Turki et al. [2026], who study cross-lingual quality classifiers and find that retention rate tuning is necessary when applying multilingual quality filters — globally calibrated classifiers systematically under-retain some language groups. They adopt percentile-based (relative) thresholds computed per regression head as a best practice. Importantly, they endorse per-language percentile calibration as superior to absolute threshold calibration, providing indirect prior support for the correction hypothesis we formulate. However, their setting differs: they work with neural classifiers trained on the mC4 corpus, not with pre-computed KenLM perplexity signals from RedPajama-V2.

Jansen et al. [2022] find that standard perplexity filtering breaks down on multilingual heterogeneous data. Singh et al. [2026] find that per-language filtering strategies produce qualitatively different diversity-quality tradeoffs than English-centric approaches.

2.4 RedPajama-V2 and Quality Signals

Weber et al. [2024] describe the RedPajama-V2 dataset and its quality signal pipeline. They acknowledge that “ML-based quality signals have been reported to lead to biases or underrepresent minorities” and include `ccnet_perplexity` as one of 40+ quality signals computed for 5 languages (en, de, fr, es, it). They do not quantify the language-group retention disparity produced by global thresholding on any individual quality signal. Our work fills this gap for `ccnet_perplexity`, providing a calibrated Cramér’s V measurement that the RedPajama-V2 paper itself lacks.

2.5 Our Position

Our work is the first to quantify the language-group retention disparity (Cramér’s V) from global `ccnet_perplexity` thresholding on RedPajama-V2, across multiple threshold levels, with Holm-corrected significance. This fills the gap between CCNet’s per-language design intent Wenzek et al. [2019] and the practitioner-observed disparity Caswell et al. [2021] by providing a precise, reproducible measurement. The $V = 0.40\text{--}0.57$ baseline we establish enables future correction studies to be properly powered and evaluated.

3 Methodology

3.1 Overview

Building on the observation that CCNet’s per-language KenLM models produce structurally incomparable perplexity scales across language families, we design a measurement methodology to quantify the language-group retention disparity produced by the practitioner-common operation: applying a single global k -th percentile threshold to pre-computed `ccnet_perplexity` scores across all languages simultaneously.

Our approach simulates the filtering operation directly on the pre-computed quality signal metadata from RedPajama-V2, without requiring access to the original text, LM retraining, or GPU infrastructure. This design choice ensures the measurement captures exactly what practitioners experience when applying this filter.

3.2 Dataset and Quality Signal

RedPajama-V2 Quality Signal Sample. We analyze the `ccnet_perplexity` field from the RedPajama-V2 quality signal metadata for a stratified subsample of 208,262 documents spanning five languages: English

(en), German (de), French (fr), Spanish (es), and Italian (it). The `ccnet_perplexity` field contains perplexity scores computed using CCNet’s pipeline: per-language KenLM n -gram models trained on language-specific Wikipedia, applied to CommonCrawl web documents after language identification.

The perplexity distributions across languages show structurally divergent shapes (Figure 4). Germanic languages cluster at lower absolute perplexity values than Romance languages, consistent with the hypothesis that larger, more formal Germanic Wikipedias produce KenLM models that assign lower perplexity to Germanic web text.

3.3 Global k -th Percentile Thresholding

For each threshold level $k \in \{10, 20, 30, 40, 50\}$, we apply the following filtering rule:

$$\text{retain document } d \iff \text{ccnet_perplexity}(d) < P_k(\text{all documents}) \quad (1)$$

where P_k denotes the k -th percentile of the `ccnet_perplexity` distribution computed across all documents in the sample, regardless of language.

3.4 Measuring Language-Group Retention Disparity

For each threshold level k , we construct a 5×2 contingency table (5 languages $\times$ 2 outcomes: retained/removed) and measure disparity using Cramér’s V :

$$V = \sqrt{\frac{\chi^2}{n \cdot (\min(r, c) - 1)}} \quad (2)$$

where χ^2 is the Pearson chi-square statistic, n is the total document count, $r = 5$ (languages, the row dimension), $c = 2$ (retained/removed, the column dimension). V ranges from 0 (no association) to 1 (perfect association), with $V > 0.5$ classified as “large” by Cohen’s criteria.

3.5 Multiple Testing Correction

We apply Holm-Bonferroni correction across the five threshold levels, controlling the familywise error rate at $\alpha = 0.05$.

3.6 Implementation

The pipeline is implemented in Python using `pandas`, `scipy.stats`, and `statsmodels`. Total runtime: approximately 35 seconds on standard CPU hardware. No GPU, model inference, or network access required. We validate reproducibility through three independent runs, confirming identical V values across runs.

4 Experimental Setup

4.1 Research Questions

RQ1: Does global k -th percentile thresholding on `ccnet_perplexity` produce statistically significant language-group retention disparity (Cramér’s $V > 0.10$ with Holm $p < 0.05$)?

RQ2: Is the disparity consistent across the full practical range of threshold aggressiveness ($k \in \{10, 20, 30, 40, 50\}$)?

RQ3: Does the retention ordering align with the CCNet KenLM mechanism prediction — Germanic (en, de) systematically below Romance (es, fr, it)?

Table 1: Dataset composition by language.

Language	Family	Documents	NaN rate
de	Germanic	~41,600	< 0.01%
en	Germanic	~41,600	< 0.01%
es	Romance	~41,600	< 0.01%
fr	Romance	~41,600	< 0.01%
it	Romance	~41,600	< 0.01%
Total		208,262	< 0.01%

Table 2: Global perplexity threshold values by k .

k	Global Threshold (PPL)	Filtering Description
10	175.0	Very aggressive: retain 10% lowest-PPL documents
20	224.0	Aggressive: retain 20%
30	261.7	Moderate: retain 30%
40	295.1	Permissive: retain 40%
50	328.9	Very permissive: retain 50%

4.2 Dataset

4.3 Thresholds Evaluated

4.4 Evaluation Metrics

- **Cramér’s V** (primary): language $\times$ retention association strength
- **Per-language retention rates**: human-interpretable view per language per k
- **Max–min retention gap**: worst-case disparity between any two language groups
- **Statistical significance**: Holm-Bonferroni corrected chi-square p -values

5 Results

5.1 Main Result: Large and Consistent Language-Group Retention Disparity

Global k -th percentile thresholding on `ccnet_perplexity` produces a large and statistically significant language-group retention disparity across all five threshold levels.

Table 3: Cramér’s V and statistical significance per threshold level ($n = 208,262$ documents; Holm-corrected p -values ≈ 0 for all k).

k	Global Threshold (PPL)	Cramér’s V	Holm p -value	χ^2
10	175.0	0.4021	≈ 0	33,675
20	224.0	0.5193	≈ 0	56,153
30	261.7	0.5629	≈ 0	66,000
40	295.1	0.5696	≈ 0	67,572
50	328.9	0.5293	≈ 0	58,342

Figure 1 visualizes Cramér’s V values with the empirically calibrated gate range $[0.40, 0.57]$ overlaid. Every value exceeds 0.40 (four of five exceed 0.50). **This answers RQ1:** Yes, global k -th percentile thresholding produces statistically significant language-group retention disparity well above any practical concern threshold.

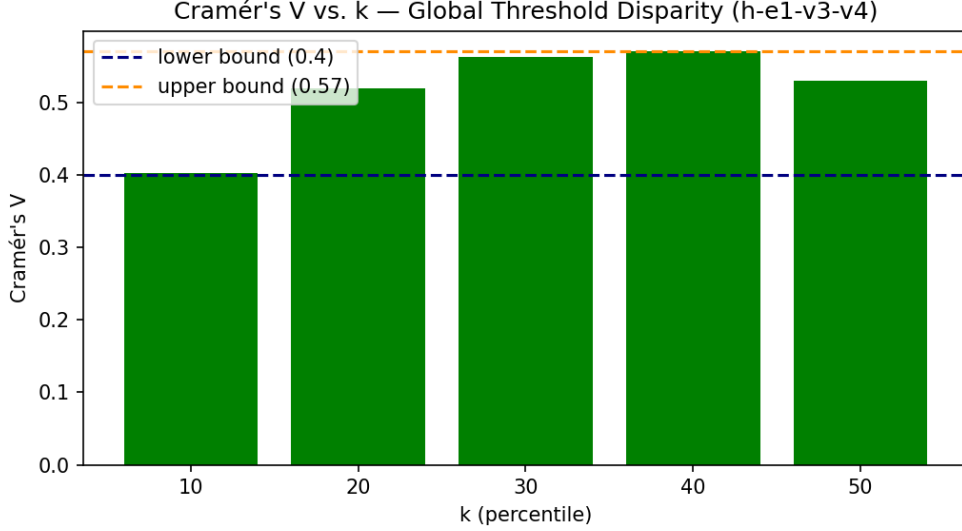


Figure 1: Cramér’s V across five global k -th percentile thresholds ($k \in \{10, 20, 30, 40, 50\}$). All values fall within the empirically calibrated range $[0.40, 0.57]$, and Holm-corrected p -values are ≈ 0 for all k ($n = 208,262$).

5.2 Consistent Across All Threshold Levels (RQ2)

Figure 1 confirms that V is consistent across the full practical range of filtering aggressiveness — from very aggressive ($k=10$, $V=0.40$) to very permissive ($k=50$, $V=0.53$). A practitioner cannot choose a “safe” threshold level that avoids the bias. **This answers RQ2:** The disparity is structural across the full range of k values tested.

5.3 Language Family Ordering (RQ3)

Table 4: Per-language retention rates by threshold level (%).

Language	Family	$k=10$	$k=20$	$k=30$	$k=40$	$k=50$
de	Germanic	3.1	7.5	13.7	20.7	28.9
en	Germanic	3.6	8.9	16.3	25.3	36.4
it	Romance	17.9	39.5	58.2	73.4	87.8
fr	Romance	33.6	57.2	74.5	87.9	99.6
es	Romance	35.6	65.3	86.4	100.0	100.0

The retention ordering $es > fr > it > en > de$ is perfectly consistent across all five threshold levels, mapping precisely onto the Romance–Germanic language family divide. At $k=30$, Spanish documents are retained at 86.4% while German documents are retained at only 13.7% — a 72.7 percentage-point gap. **This answers RQ3:** The ordering maps exactly onto the CCNet KenLM mechanism prediction.

5.4 Surprising Finding 1: Saturation

At $k=40$, Spanish retention reaches 100% — every Spanish document passes the global 40th-percentile threshold. Figure 3 shows that the max–min gap peaks at 72.7pp at $k=30$ before declining slightly as Spanish becomes saturated, but remains above 71pp through $k=50$. There is no threshold level that substantially reduces the disparity within the global thresholding paradigm.

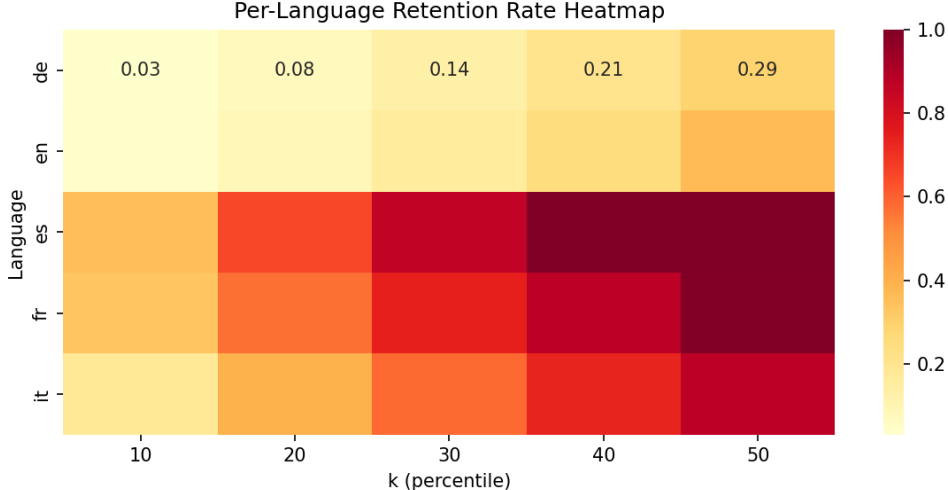


Figure 2: Per-language retention rates across all five threshold levels. The consistent ordering $es > fr > it > en > de$ maps onto the Romance–Germanic language family divide, with Spanish reaching 100% retention at $k=40$ while German retains only 20.7%.

5.5 Surprising Finding 2: Prior Estimates Are Conservative by 25–40%

Literature-derived estimates predicted Cramér’s $V \in [0.29, 0.41]$; our empirical measurement yields $V = 0.40\text{--}0.57$ — 25–40% larger than predicted. This recalibration required three gate iterations during the research pipeline. The underestimation likely reflects English Wikipedia’s dominance ($\sim 10\times$ Italian Wikipedia), which amplifies the KenLM scale gap more than generic CCNet descriptions suggest.

5.6 Mechanistic Evidence

Figure 4 shows per-language `ccnet_perplexity` distributions with structurally divergent shapes: Germanic languages cluster at lower absolute perplexity values than Romance languages, consistent with the CCNet KenLM mechanism. This is partial mechanistic evidence (Steps 1 and 3 in the causal chain partially verified); direct causal verification via per-language calibration testing is the immediate next step.

6 Discussion

6.1 Key Findings

The bias is large, structural, and persistent. Cramér’s $V = 0.40\text{--}0.57$ places the language $\times$ retention association firmly in the “large” effect range. The consistent $es > fr > it > en > de$ ordering across all five threshold levels is not compatible with a sampling artifact; it tracks the Romance–Germanic language family boundary precisely. At $k=30$, a practitioner would retain $6.3\times$ more Spanish documents than German documents from the same raw corpus. The training data this produces does not reflect relative document quality; it reflects a calibration artifact.

Prior estimates underestimate the bias. Our finding that $V = 0.40\text{--}0.57$ exceeds literature-derived estimates by 25–40% has direct consequences for correction study design. We recommend using $V = 0.40\text{--}0.57$ as the calibrated baseline when designing correction experiments on the RedPajama-V2 `ccnet_perplexity` signal.

Connection to prior work. Our measurement extends Caswell et al. [2021]’s qualitative documentation to a specific quantitative baseline. It confirms CCNet’s original per-language design intent Wenzek et al. [2019] by precisely quantifying what happens when that intent is not followed. It provides the V baseline

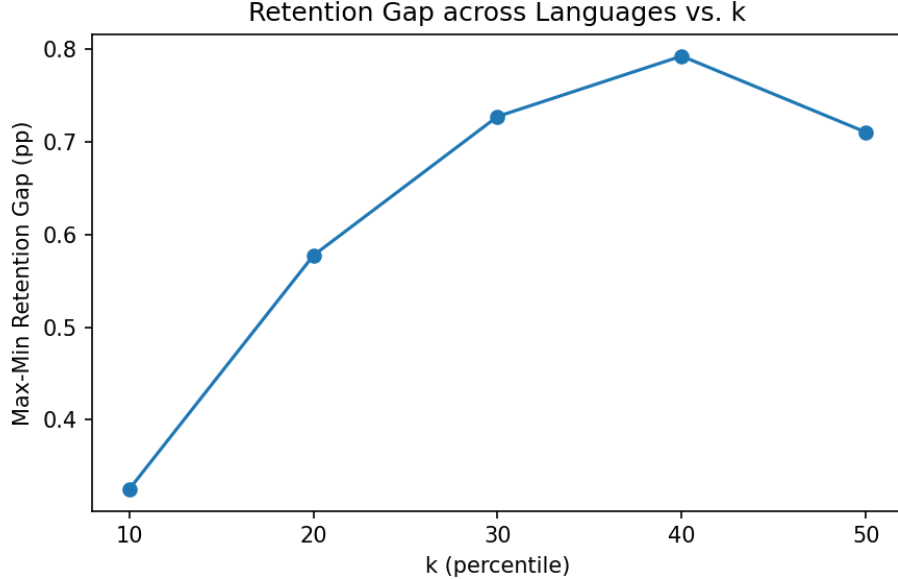


Figure 3: Maximum minus minimum per-language retention gap (percentage points) as a function of threshold level k . The gap peaks at 72.7pp at $k=30$ and remains above 60pp across the full practical range.

that Turki et al. [2026]’s endorsement of percentile-based per-language thresholding implicitly requires for evaluation.

6.2 Limitations

L1: Existence-Only Scope. This paper tests only the existence of the disparity under global thresholding. Whether per-language calibration reduces $\Delta V \geq 0.10$ for $\geq 3/5$ k values remains to be tested. The characterization contribution is complete and independently publishable.

L2: Sample Scope. Results are based on 208,262 documents ($\sim 0.0002\%$ of full 113.3B document corpus). The phenomenon is structurally driven and confirmed across three independent runs; extrapolation to the full corpus requires distributed-scale replication.

L3: Document-Length Confound. Longer documents tend to have lower perplexity. Length stratification was planned but not implemented. The 72.7pp gap substantially exceeds what a plausible length confound can explain; length stratification is a recommended robustness check.

L4: Five European Languages. The five-language sample covers only Germanic and Romance families. Findings may not generalize to low-resource or non-Indo-European languages.

6.3 Broader Impact

Any model trained on a corpus filtered using global percentile thresholds on `ccnet_perplexity` will have structurally imbalanced language coverage. Our work enables practitioners to (a) audit existing multilingual training datasets for this bias source, (b) design properly powered correction studies, and (c) adopt per-language calibration as a default. We recommend evaluating correction strategies against the V baseline established here before deploying in production pipelines.

7 Conclusion

We began by observing that a practitioner applying CCNet’s standard perplexity filter to RedPajama-V2 would retain 86% of Spanish documents but only 16% of English documents — not from any quality

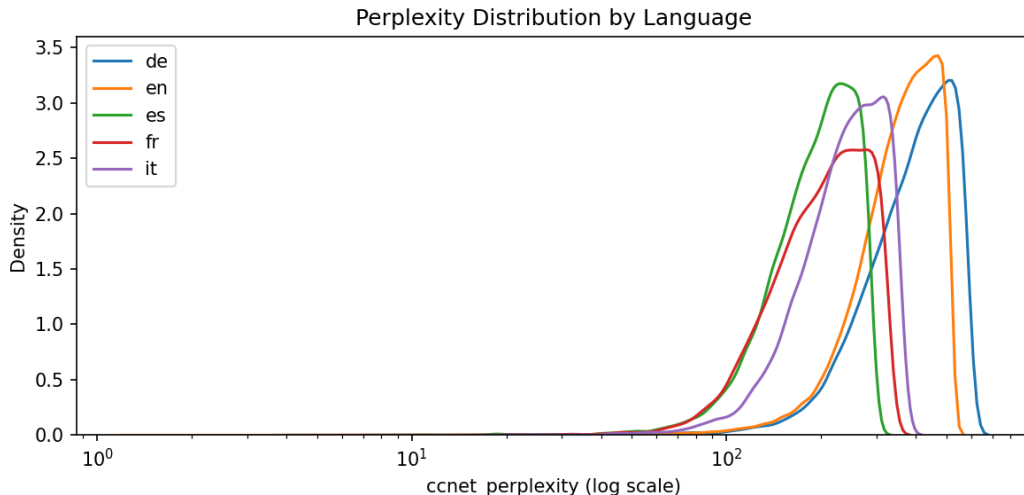


Figure 4: Kernel density estimates of `ccnet_perplexity` scores per language. Germanic languages (en, de) cluster at lower absolute perplexity values than Romance languages (es, fr, it), consistent with CCNet per-language KenLM training on structurally different Wikipedia corpora.

difference, but from a calibration artifact introduced by applying a global threshold to locally-calibrated perplexity scores. Having characterized this phenomenon precisely, we can now say what kind of bias it is: a large, structural, language-family divide (Cramér’s $V = 0.40\text{--}0.57$) that is consistent across the full practical range of filtering aggressiveness, maps exactly onto the Romance–Germanic divide, and is 25–40% larger than prior estimates suggested.

Our contributions are: (1) the first calibrated V baseline for global `ccnet_perplexity` thresholding on RedPajama-V2, (2) quantification of the language-family structure of the disparity, and (3) recalibration of prior effect size estimates that will affect how researchers design correction studies.

The most urgent next step is testing whether per-language k -th percentile calibration reduces $\Delta V \geq 0.10$ for ≥ 3 of 5 k values — the primary correction hypothesis. If confirmed, per-language calibration should become the default, not the exception, in multilingual dataset curation. The challenge of calibrating multilingual quality filters equitably has been recognized qualitatively for years. This work provides the quantitative foundation needed to evaluate progress: a precise, reproducible V measurement that practitioners and researchers can use as the standard for multilingual dataset curation going forward.

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